#37

AdventureOC

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CREDITS

Cover: The original cover was drawn up this summer by our illustrious Danish artist Nicolai Grut. However, due to last minute disasters (I lost it), I dug through my old files and found this one. Drawn by Rachel Nemec, an American artist from Pittsburgh, it is entitled "The Black Hills"; a look across the valley of the Black Forest in the Borderlands.

The

Renegades

Chapter XXI: The Ambush

Through a storm of encounters, the Renegades found a great price upon their lives, and fought to uncover the enemy. Backed by Baron Zod, they issued a reward for the heads of Fyrth One-Eye, the thief Thistle, Lord Ilrajhir and any member of the Death Cult.

As Autumn of the year 3119n came and went, The Renegades assailed valiantly the city of Hagar to further the cause of Dalmatia; happening upon the dying page of Sir Arasdine of Armington, the party rushed to deliver the knight's warning to the King of Arnor. There, in the great halls of Cran Moor, they were asked once again to find the Throne of Talanasron and deliver it to the King - Kipox, as Knight of Arnor, took up the quest and was joined solemnly by Sir Warren and the others.

Their quest led them on the trail of a long-dead adventurer named Garn Lorinslayer - a trail that in time took them to the City of Thieves: Dryer Mob.

It was a cold day in the city, with the first of the Winter Winds howling through the streets. Soon it would be the time of Akania's brief snows. For now the city was still alive, with the sights unchanged since the days of Lord Mob himself; save only the flags of Dalmatia and Khitai that flew above the city. Yet no matter the army, no matter the empire, Dryer Mob could never change.

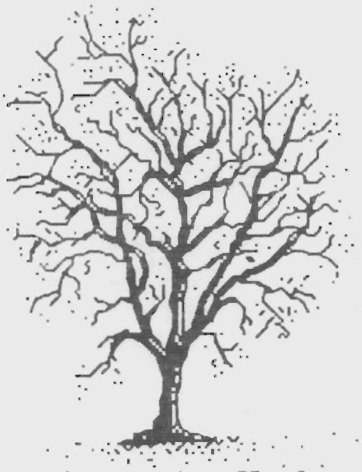
In the Square of Doryn some adventurers had gathered; a haffer, an elven mage, a Southron and a Westron.

"He should be here by now, Corbin!" whispered the halfling impatiently. This was Kipox Thief; to the eyes of any self-respecting local, this was a thief of great renown, from the streets of their own city - an adventurer whose tales floated through every bar and whose victims lay scattered across Numedia.

"Don't worry, he'll come. Grorkin and Og should be with him, too, so don't worry." answered the one called Corbin. This also, was not just an elven mage, but Lord Corbin Sindar, Thane of Gereth Minar.

"The sooner they get here, the sooner we can leave." responded the Southron. This wasn't truly a Southron, but rather a half-elf with mixed blood. Clad in loose clothes, this was Amrik the Druid.

"Exactly." muttered the Westron. This was Sark, a Templer Assassin hired by Kipox to help them this day.



At that moment a shimmering in the air got their attention, followed by the sudden appearance of a great knight in dragon-emblazoned armor, a dwarf in chain mail and an axe, and an orc heavilly cloaked from the sun. They rushed over to the others, looking warily about.

"*We got your message. You said you found the Death Cult?*" asked the knight, his hand on the hilt of his claymore. He fought with shield and sword, wielding single-handedly the great blade at his side; this alone should say enough about his skill and might.

"*We found two of them - one here and the other in Caberton. The one here was Tirion, and he nearly...Well, he almost got me. He's gone; we're going to teleport to where the other one is and surprise him. Coming?*"

"*Aar, you bet we're a comin', Kipox. Where would you kids be without me?*" grumbled the dwarf, smiling proudly at the others.

With that they gathered again, all holding hands around the orb that Warren carried. They vanished in a moment, reappearing on the empty docks of Caberton. They looked hurredly around them, stepping quickly into an alley; perched across the bay lay the city, climbing its way up the steep mountainside to the top of the cliff they faced. A chopping wind struck the water, and all the place was silent. To their left the docks made their cold way around the port to the city itself, jammed with closed warehouses and assorted shacks full of the trade that passed through this city.

"Well, druid?" asked Warren. Amrik looked up at the party:

"Okay, okay." With that he leapt into the air, turning into a swift hawk. He flew along the docks, looking carefully for the warehouse the Soothsayer had told them about. Corbin slowly opened his eyes:

"It's not within 3200 feet of us - my Homunculus can't see it. Unless Karnal was wrong."

"Karnal's never wrong! We'll find it." sputtered Kipox, staring up at Corbin.

"Not only will we find it, but we'll kill every single one of them. They'll never know we were coming." muttered Sark.

"I just wish we could face them fairly." growled Warren.

"This *is* fair! Otherwise they'd rig a thousand traps and wipe us out before we saw them." argued Corbin.

"Aaarr. That would be bad." asserted Grorkin.

"Uuuh. Maybe we should run away..." mumbled Og under his breath. Kipox kicked him in the shins.

Then Amrik flew low towards them, landing back on human feet:

"I found it. It's up a ways along the shore. I looked through a window; there are four of them. A thief type, two warriors and a mage. The mage isn't Echtelion, though - but one of the warriors could be Dorg Rath. The thief is probably Myrlandrius. Oh yeah, it's only one floor."

"Good, then let's go."



The Renegades walked cautiously and slowly up the docks, Corbin casting spells here and there, his hands touching others as he mumbled words of power in the air. Occasionally he pulled an object from his robes, or gestured. All with the subtle skill and concentration of the higher orders. Lord Corbin had long since earned his title as Wizard of the Arts.

Soon they came to the building; it had its back to the stone of the mountain, and two great sliding doors on the front for merchandise. High on the facade were small windows for light. The invisible little Homunculus perched himself right next to a window to watch for any sign of alarm within.

"Move behind me!" ordered Corbin, raising his hands. He pulled them slowly together, his arms tensing as he gathered his strength to battle the magic surrounding the place - then he threw his power ahead of him with a thrust of the head, smiling grimly as he won.

Sweating he threw an arm forward, lightning shooting out to blast the door off its hinges - it shook the building.

But then, as they all ran forward, arrows poured out from the windows above - a mere nuisance, as Sark sent a knife into an assailant's throat. But Corbin slowed his pace - his Homunculus still saw the same empty room with no reaction from the four inside.

"Simple solution," muttered Kipox, firing into the bodies within. But his arrows passed through them.

"Some kind of illusion - come on!" bellowed Warren, charging in. Grorkin followed him, axe in hand. But as the dwarf raised his axe, still some feet from the entrance, he was lifted from the ground and thrown a hundred feet behind them all - to fall screaming down the slope.

Despite Og's apparent glee, the others growled and charged on. They poured into the room, seeing its true contents only as they passed the threshold: an empty warehouse with a ceiling above them hinting at a second floor. They raced for the door at the other end, except Warren who stepped back with Amrik

And then the whole ceiling fell on them.



o the battle had begun; the ambush had turned around and caught the attackers by surprise. Grorkin was lost - maybe dead. In truth the Death Cult, or the members inside, had been utterly surprised; only a last defense that Lord Corbin had not dispelled saved them from catastrophe. But even faced with seeming defeat and an exhiliration turned to cold surprise, the Renegades faught on. These adventurers were not sung of from dale to mountainpeak for nothing.

Voices were everywhere - but only silence reigned inside the room; some spell to hinder them. But in the air a hundred words passed through minds.

Corbin was forcing the boards to break free above him.

Og was hurt but alive.

Sark was unconscious.

Kipox was furious; he crawled under the debris, making for Warren.

And then Warren was thrown forward, a knife slamming uselessly against his armored back. Taken offguard, he swung wildly behind him - the *shadow* (as were often called invisible things) took flight. Just then the door opened, a ball of flame shooting once more for Warren. He raised his shield, parrying the weak magik, and then clambered over the wreckage towards the fledgling User.

The mage lifted his hands up for another quick spell, then gasped, leaping backwards: Corbin burst through the floorboards, sword in hand. The young human slammed the door, bolting it.

Corbin, Kipox and Warren pounded the door open, running up the steps. Reaching a closed trap door, they thrust their weight against it, feeling the strength of a strong brace against them.

And down below, unnoticed by the others, Amrik felt the knife of the shadow. Trained in Martial Arts, he could sense this enemy and leap from hism as he slashed - a losing battle, as the killer was skilled.

"Myrlandrius!" gasped the druid, but no sound came from his lips. A silence fluttered around the thief.

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"Upstairs the party burst through, Warren closing blades with the warrior while the others crossed to fight the mage - the only other body in the room had Sark's knife in his throat.

Corbin sent five balls of fire to the novice, roasting him as he screamed. Then, turning, they saw the warrior lean in and throw Warren a foot towards them

with his shoulder, keeping them all to one side - then he leapt down the stairs, running. In a rage, Warren chased him out, quickly closing the distance, until he faced him silently below.

Within a few sword strokes the battle was decided, the fighter rolling headless to the foor. Now, the others there, they caught sight of Amrik's desperate plight - closing the distance quickly, Kipox swapped blows with his rival, until Myrlandrius fled. Chasing after him, Kipox threw a balled wad of spidery web towards the shadow - it unfolded in the air to cover a ten foot area, falling over the thief. But Myrlandrius was quick - he jumped to avoid, falling to a roll and then leaping to a sprint all in one. Cursing, Kipox soon lost the shadow among the buildings that made up the city of Caberton.

They sacked the warehouse, finding some small loot. Amrik discovered Grorkin, and healed his broken bones. Sark also survived, though as badly off as the dwarf.

"Not a great success, that one." muttered Grorkin.

"It could have been worse. I mean, we killed three of them - even if they weren't full members. We at least burnt one of their hide-outs down - I think that's insult enough to them." answered Corbin.

"And now we know something about the thief." added Kipox sourly.

"Yeah...he's a wimp." muttered Og. Amrik glared at him.

The Renegades travelled on from here by horseback, crossing the low mountains called Sir Morin by the dwarves, or Lesser Weatherpeaks. They left the winds and came briefly through the sweating forests of West Akania. From there there they fought their way to Kristenhall, after spending much time in the Barony of Doriath, in the city of Luthien. Under the ruins of Sir Warren's southernmost lands, they discovered the treasure trove of Garn Lorinslayer, and with the grace of Bel, robbed it blind. Yet still the Throne eluded them.



The
RENEGADES
Wrapsheet
The Adventure Log Magazine

2123 California Street, January 1989
3115n, 12940s, 9027kh, and 4810a.

TELRHIN UPDATE

There is a strenghtening peace through the lands.

The powers of Golsied are entrenching themselves in the Scarlet Hills at Tyrn Gorthad, the main Fortress, Drast and Ildengrad; in the Weatherpeaks the First Army is still encamped under the Hunter at Darkhall; in Vijmania the Second Army is position under Ilrajir at Mandolin. They have given a certain independence to the Borderlands and Bardor.

The Borderlands have been working incessantly on their new citadel of Ravenloft, where their largest forces are gathered.

Bardor has retreated to their coastal waters but is rumored to be planning an assault on Shem.

Destin has given amnesty to all rebels in its territories and is quickly establishing a peaceful hold on Alasdar and the surrounding occupied lands of Semetria. The Eastern Army is encamped at Port Dalanes where great construction is under way. Kingmage Titani sent three chests of Shields (Destin's new Gold Coin) and an offering of peace to King Estilon; this was followed by the relinquishment of Arnum by Destinite soldiers and all of Dash Krintor returned to Arnor.

Dalmatia has retreated from Ugar in an effort to strengthen the borders along the Ashen River. As the river flooded the city, Asgardian soldiers assaulted it, outnumbering the defending Khitani and Dalmatian forces - yet the Duke of Tamaria, Sir Tinaden, arrived in time to save the day.

Arnor has agreed to a peace with Destin. They are recruiting help to rebuild the cities of Timbred, Arnum, Tharbad and Von Tinas.

Lark-Han has regained some prestige as it now once again rules the Valek; with the retreat of Bardor, the Scarlet Brotherhood has followed suit and will not face the strength of the Zodian Navy. The price has been high, as Baron Zod is requesting higher taxes from all his protectorate cities.

Zhân has closed all borders, shooting without warning any who enter the mountains without a Zhânian banner. It is rumored that the Thane of Cawdor is threatening succession.

Nation	Rate	Change	Predictions
Golsied	*30*	*-*	*stable*
Borderlands	*10*	*new*	*up*
Bardor	*08*	*new*	*up*
Destin	*23*	*+*	*up*
Ugar	*21*	*++*	*stable*

Arnor	*15*	*new*	*stable*
Dalmatia	*20*	*new*	*up*
Zhân	*20*	*new*	*down*
Kraghorin	*03*	*new*	*down*
Lark-Han	*20*	*new*	*up*

The Warbonds Office has divided the categories into each nation as open war has subsided. Some nations imply or include others still:

Arnor - Dramia and Semetria
Dalmatia - Khitai and all Colonies
Lark-Han - Port Zolna
Zhân - Port Lanion

Fables of Telrhin
Fable 23
The Skeleton Closet

*I*t was said that when Dalmatia was reborn, an age of turmoil would arise; an age of war, and age of adventure. But even more so, it would be an age of heroes.

And villains.

The little boy sat in the small garden of his house. He sat, and played with his kitten, smiling. He was a Southron, of no great lineage; a lonely boy who had for company only the sun, the trees of the garden and his little kitten. He sat, watching as the cat played with a little scrap of yarn, until suddenly he looked up and saw the man walking towards him.

Timmy had been told not to talk to strangers, of course, but this man was in his garden. He looked up, smiling shyly:

"Hello." he said, feeling the warmth of the kitten's body as he curled up in his lap.

"Hello, lad. Is that your kitten?"

The voice of the stranger was soft and delicate; he was a Southron, little Timmy noticed, and that made him feel better. He was dressed in black, and had a faint oily smell of metal. The smell reminded him of his father, especially when he heard the soft jingle of the chain links like his father wore. There was something uninviting in his eye, however. He answered the man, smiling broadly at the attention he showed him, and handed him his kitten with great pride.

"His name is Tybalt, sir. He's my best friend in the whole world."

The man took the kitten gently in his hands, feeling its soft purr. He lifted it, and stood over the kid.

"The world's a lonely place, kid." with that he squeezed the cat, snapping its neck.

The kid looked up in shock, his eyes wide, his throat unable to make a sound. The man stood, smiling:

"Hurry up and scream, kid. I want your dad to watch me disembowel you." the kid sat there, mutely, until he kicked him in the stomach. He fell backwards with a grunt; he turned and looked towards the house:

"DADDY!" he screamed. The man smiled, waiting.

Inside his father heard the shout, and leaped out of his seat. He grabbed his sheathed sword off the mantle and ran to the door; he threw it open:

"Timmy!" he gasped, taking in the scene. He then looked to the man, recognition in his eyes. Fear crept into his soul, as images of times ago slowly filtered their dusty way into his mind. The stranger bowed gracefully:

"What's the matter, Naules? Is this the way to greet an old

friend?"

The man stiffened, looking first to his son who lay at the stranger's feet in shock.

"Please, Ecthelion; not my child. Kill me, but not my son!"

"That's right, Naules; I do owe you a favor, don't I? Right before you betrayed our plot to the king, you did save my life, didn't you? Well, I'll spare your whelp." With that he kicked Timmy on the side of his head with his mailed boot, sending him bleeding to the ground.

Naules stared at his foe, drawing his sword slowly. He realized one thing when he saw Ecthelion move; he was wearing armor. He could not cast his spells. Naules threw himself forward, drawing his blade with long remembered skill. He knew that his only chance lay in fighting sword to sword.

His drawn blade rang soundly on the stranger's who whipped his katana out with precision. The force of Naules' charge sent them both rolling to the ground, struggling together as they fell. Their swords were thrown from their hands, and soon it was a matter of strength and claws - Ecthelion slinked with cat-like grace away from Naules' furious assault, despite the bulk of his armor.

By now Timmy's mother had heard the fight, and ran from the nearby well to the house. She ran through the gates and stopped short, seeing her husband sprawled on the ground beneath the preying grasp of the stranger. His eyes darted to her, and he smiled slyly:

"Welcome, madame; welcome to your husband's death." he drew his hand up high, a foul-bladed contraption wrapped as gauntlet around it. Pausing only for a moment to catch the glimpse of horror on his victim's face, he plunged it into his chest. Naules gasped, his heart's blood pouring itself out into the air. His eyes then went dim, and froze in their last glimpse of life.

"Fool. To think I would let you best me; I need no magic to destroy your flesh and rip it open." he then turned to the wife, who screamed, staggering back blindly towards the gate.

Timmy watched his father die. He sat, watching, his world destroyed before his eyes. He watched as the stranger plunged his hand into his father's heart; he watched as the man raped his mother, and he watched as he slit her throat.

Ecthelion walked to the boy, satiated in his raging thirst for pain and blood. He stood over the boy:

"Whelp. I stand by my word, little rat; I will let you live this day, so that the memories of it haunt your every night."

He then laughed, throwing his head back in the exultation of his victory. He unstrapped his chainmail, and rolled it with his hands until it was no larger than a dripping heart. He dropped it into a pocket, and with a snap vanished.

Timmy stared in waking horror at the bodies of his parents. His eyes went to the blood that dripped from his mother's throat, and then they were drawn to the golden amulet that hung around it. He looked at the symbol of the mountain lion there,

and as he did the eyes came to life; the image leaped to life, and stood there before him. She purred a great roar, and walked to little Timmy with a motherly step; Timmy got up and ran to her, bursting into tears for the first time. He hugged the beast, and she spoke to him:

"Timares, come with me and I will take you into my care; we will climb the slopes above the city and grow. I will teach you strength, and I will teach you to sing at the moon and hunt through the woods that surround Karm Tor."

And so the Goddess Savana took Timares son of Naules and raised him beneath the snows of the Tricap Peaks.

THE RAT PAGE
A New Look at Spells

by the DC Combat Rat

Well, what is a spell in Telrhin? The image of Raistln in the ***Dragonlance Chronicles*** comes to mind, where the effort to draw the power from the Aigrim exhausts the caster. In the case of scrolls, the effort has already been spent, but being a conduit for such power is still exhilarating.

So, enough of that. I was sleeping in Chris' filing cabinet, and I ran across a few spells he had been pondering. So naturally I copied 'em and sneaked them into the log:

MAGE SPELLS

Second Sphere

Firebrand 1sg to cast/dur 1 turn/1 item by touch/VM(fire lizard tongue):
This causes a blade of any length to blaze afire and cause an additional 1 point of damage every successful strike. Also, it will set fire to any combustibles it touches and melt ice, etc. as fire.

Illluck 1turn to cast/dur 1 year/1 person at 1 mile/VSM(hair of victim):
Counters powers of Ring of Luck or other Luck items. Otherwise lowers bonuses to hit by 1, Cm by 1 and renders victim infertile until a Remove Curse or similar spell is cast.

Seventh Sphere

Newborn 1day to cast/permanent/1 person by touch/VSM(ruby worth exactly 10,000):
This spell allows the recipient to reroll all attributes and keep any two he prefers. However, the caster must reroll one random attribute and average it with his own. This spell may only be cast once per character, and may be cast on the caster.

Ninth Sphere

Agony 2sg to cast/instant/100ft sq/V:
With this spell the caster can dish out 900hp of damage to anyone or everyone within the area of effect. It may be distributed in any fashion, regardless of proximity. The only restriction is that the victims must be seen by the caster, and the damage will only take them to 0hp. ST at penalty of 4 negates.

DRUID SPELLS

First Sphere

Ock 3sg to cast/1 round/1 person by touch/V:
This reduces damage by 1hp per hit.

Second Sphere

Ock Ock 3sg to cast/1 round + 1sg per level/1 person by touch/V:
This doubles Armor Value, with a minimum of 2hp reduced per hit.

Skillo 1rnd to cast/1 person by touch/VS:
This spell allows the best possible roll on a SC roll for any skill used by the recipient.

Third Sphere

Olin 3sg to cast/1 round + 1sg per level/1 person per touch/V:
This bestows limited immunity to weapons of wood or using wood (staves, arrows, bolts, wooden-shafted maces, lances, etc). Attacker has no bonuses when using these weapons and damage is halved. Magic Resistance for the attacker will negate this spell, but must be rolled for each attack (not swing).

Seventh Sphere

Four Horses of the Apocalypse 7days/VS:
This places the Druid in contact with his deity, who sends forth his angels of death in a torrent upon the place in question. Each religious order carries its own myth accompanying the apocalypse, therefore the consequences vary dependent upon each order. The results are also dependent on the caster's standing with their deity.

BLUNDERBI AND FIRESTICKS

There's been a lot of talk about these little toys, so I included a full description in the next Guide. This is more or less a sneak preview.

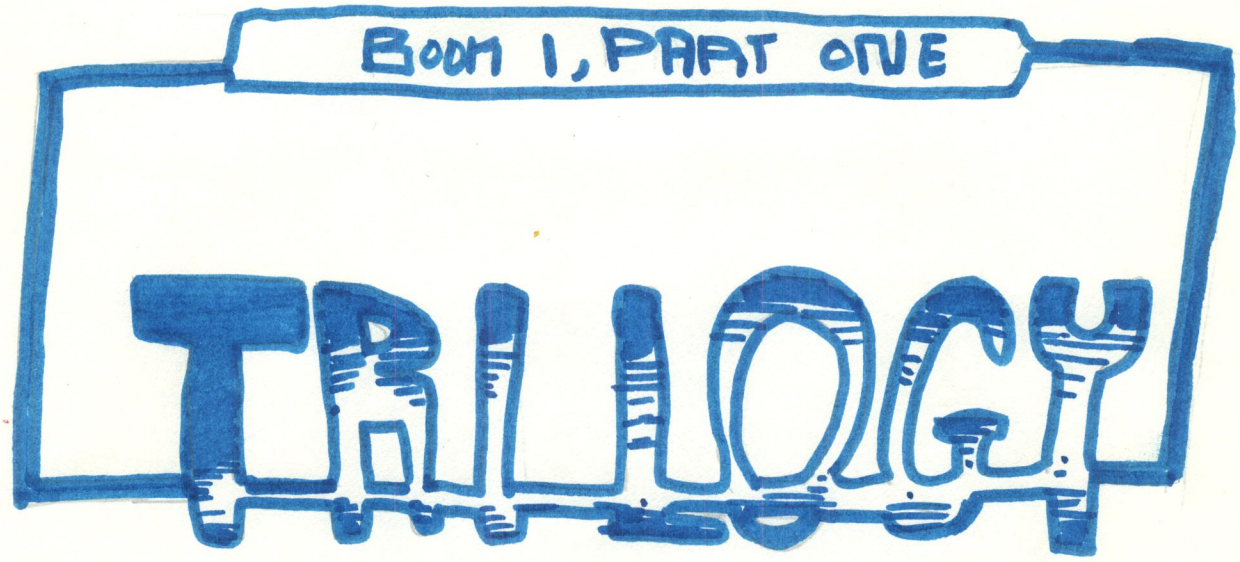
These weapons are extremely rare, and more often suicidal than effective. Discovered by the dwarves, these tools work on gunpowder, known as Hâdsh (Kh C'Blackfire'). The difficulty in keeping the hâdsh dry and weapon oiled, along with the scarceness of the hâdsh itself, perpetuate the rareness of this nasty toy.
There is a SC for a successful shot, based on the level of craftsmanship out of d8.

*This weapon has a wide dispersal range, and can hit two targets if they are within arm's length at 5yrds, and within two squares at 20yrds. It may also be loaded with anything at hand, ranging from rocks to a live chicken - the more preposterous the cargo, the higher the die rolled for SC.

**This weapon fires 2lb metal spikes. Armor value is not subtracted from damage.

***This is a fragile container or pottery, glass, etc, filled with hâdsh and a wick. It's lit and tossed - with rather unpredictable results.

name	craft	weight	range	damage	reload
pistol	1-7	2lbs	30yrds	1d12	5sg
rifle	3-7	8lbs	50yrds	2d6	6sg
blunderbuss*	1-6	10lbs	20yrds	2d8	3sg
doorblaster	1-5	12lbs	5yrds	2d12	10sg
knightfeller**	2-7	8lbs	20yrds	2d8	9sg
bomb***	0-5	2lbs	throw	3d4	-



NOTES FROM THE EDITOR

This cartoon was discovered in a pile of gaming artifacts, mostly from Planes of the Gods, that Nicolai had given my when he left the country. As that was early 1987, the pile found itself on my basement floor on Springdale, and went promptly into another heap under the church pew. I set eyes on it for the first time this past summer when Nic was in town. He told me it was something he did in Tutorial 1 and that I might as well throw it away. So here it is.

Incidently, he only wrote one and a half of the three parts of Book I (there were 3 books in his original plan). The last of his work, Part II, will appear in Adventure Log #38.

PUGH CHABAGGA WAS AN ORDINARY CALLOPIAN WHO LED AN ORDINARY LIFE UNTIL....





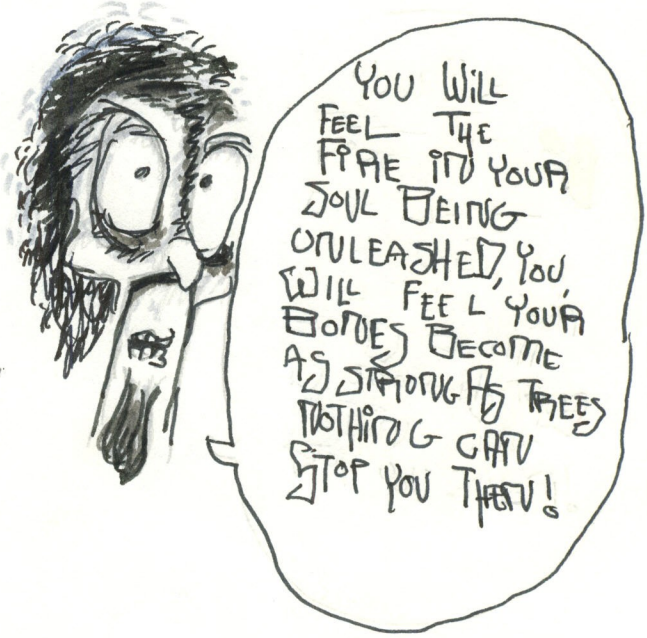


HUH!?!


AT LEAST UNTIL YOU'VE PROVED YOU'RE A MAN
BUT THAT'S EASY I MEAN I HAVE MY BIRTH CERTIFICATE AT HOME AND...
WHAT I MEAN IS YOU MUST PROVE THAT YOU'RE A WORTHY HEIR TO THE THRONE
TO HELP YOU ON THIS QUEST I WILL GIVE YOU THE SWORD OF COURAGE. IT IS SO SHARP THAT IT CUTS TREES LIKE TOOTHPICKS AND IT EVEN CUTS MY WIFE'S CAKES
A SWORD! I'M NOT EVEN ALLOWED TO PLAY WITH KNIVES

02/00/00


JUST ONE MORE THING, HOW WILL I KNOW WHEN IVE PROVED THAT IM A MAN?


YOU WILL FEEL THE FIRE IN YOUR SOUL BEING UNLEASHED, YOU WILL FEEL YOUR BONES BECOME AS STRONG AS TREES NOTHING CAN STOP YOU THEN!


SAY! THATS PRETTY GOOD! DID YOU THINK THAT UP JUST NOW OR DID YOU WRITE IT LAST NIGHT?



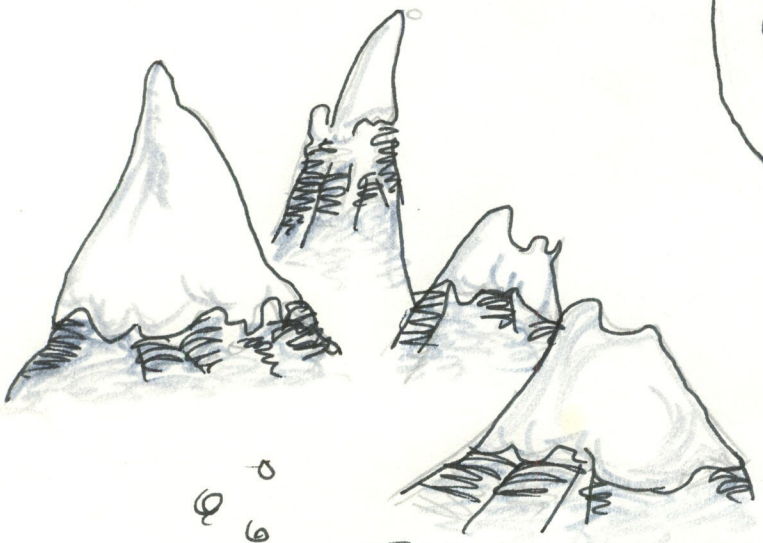


BY POINTING HIS FINGER HIS UNCLE SHOOTS HIM OFF THE MOUNTAIN TOP OR TOP OF WHICH HIS VILLAGE WAS BUILT. NOW THE CHANCES OF SURVIVING A 69000 FOOT FALL ARE VERY SMALL.

ON THE WAY DOWN HE MEETS HIS BROTHER, A CREEPY POWER HUNGRY PERSON UNLIKE HIS BROTHER PUGH.



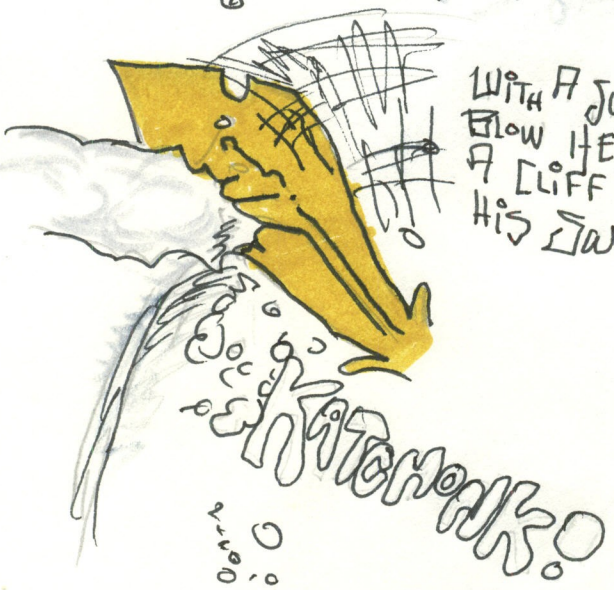
SO YOU THINK YOU'RE GOING TO RULE CALLOPRIA? WELL ONLY THE QUEST CAN DECIDE THAT!





I'VE GOT TO THINK OF SOMETHING QUICK DA! I DON'T THINK I'LL PASS MY NEXT PHYSICAL.

WITH A SWIFT BLOW HE STRIKES A CLIFF WITH HIS SWORD



05/00/00


ULP!




IF I COULD ONLY REACH THAT CAVE
I KNOW!
I'LL MAKE A BRIDGE WITH THIS TREE
CHOP
PHEW!


HOW TO TRY THE TUNNEL

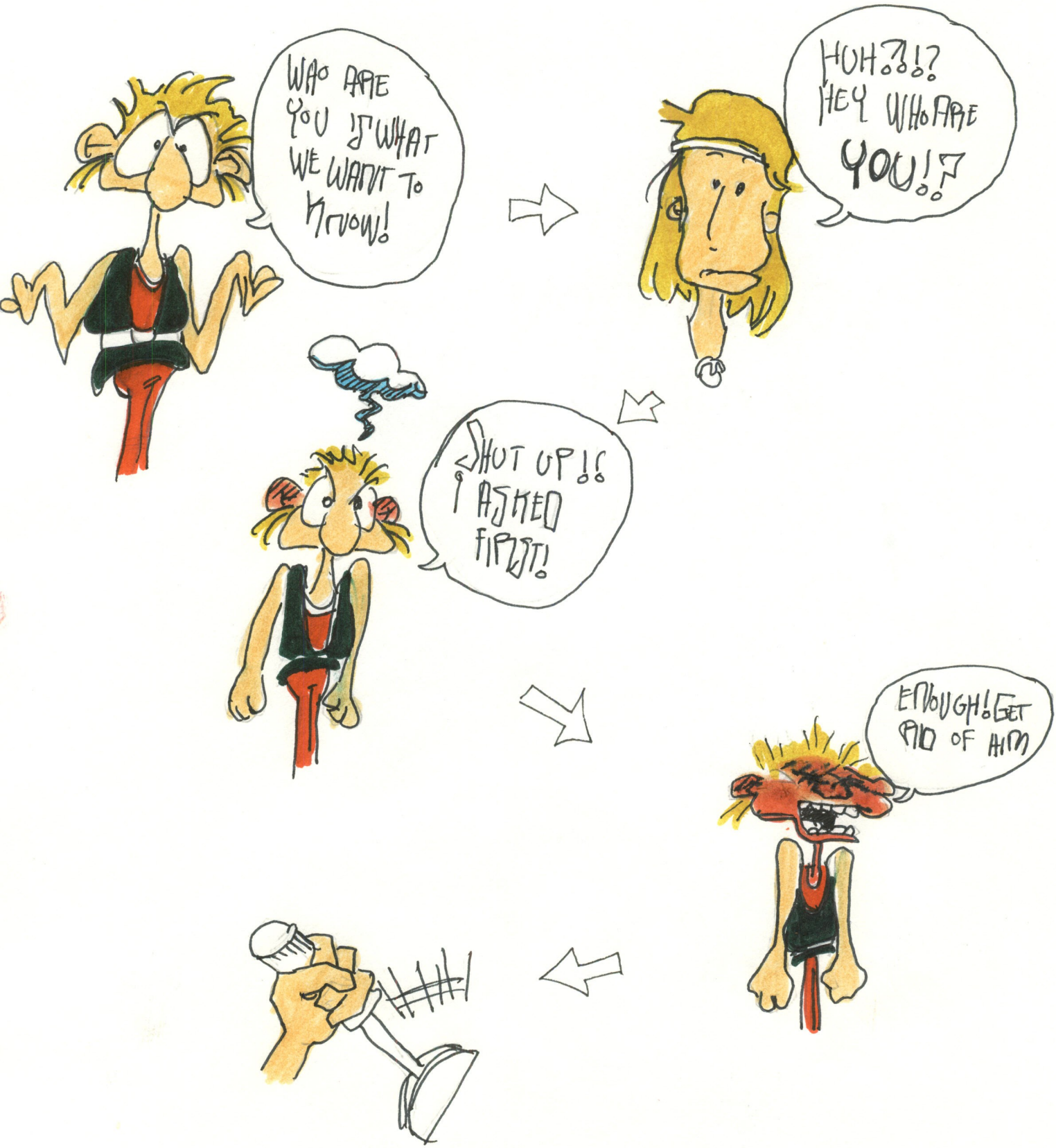

;GULP;EP... HELLO?

LATER ON


BONK
HEY WHAT'S THIS?


OW! HEY WHERE AM I?


FLOOF
SWISH
OW!
HEY!!


WHO ARE YOU !? WHAT WE WANT TO KNOW!
HUH?!? HEY WHO ARE YOU!?
SHUT UP!! I ASKED FIRST!
ENOUGH! GET RID OF HIM







HE FOUND HIMSELF TRAPPED!



TO BE CONTINUED....?

2 *Absolutism in Practice*

One of the ways in which Louis XIV tamed the nobility of France was to create a totally artificial society at Versailles in which only the nobles knew how to behave. He thus granted status to the aristocracy without having to yield any political power to them. This society may be appreciated from this brief glimpse of the social mores of the time.

FROM *The Splendid Century* BY *W. H. Lewis*

COURT ETIQUETTE WAS A life study. Who for instance could guess that at Versailles it was the height of bad manners to knock at a door? You must scratch it with the little finger of the left hand, growing the finger nail long for that purpose. Or could know that you must not *tutoyer* an intimate friend in any place where the King was present? That if the lackey of a social superior brought you a message, you had to receive him standing, and bareheaded? You have mastered the fact that you must not knock on a door, so when you go to make your first round of calls in the great houses in the town, you scratch: wrong again, you should have knocked. Next time you rattle the knocker, and a passing exquisite asks you contemptuously if you are so ignorant as not to know that you give one blow of the knocker on the door of a lady of quality? Who could guess that if you encounter the royal dinner on its way from the kitchens to the table, you must bow as to the King himself, sweep the ground with the plume of your hat, and say in a low, reverent, but distinct voice, *La viande du Roi?* Many times must the apprentice courtier have echoed the psalmist's lament, "Who can tell how oft he offendeth?" And it behoved you not to offend, for the King had an eye like a hawk, or shall we say, like a school prefect, for any breach of etiquette, and not even the most exalted were safe from his reproof. One night at supper his chatterbox of a brother put his hand in a dish before Louis had helped himself: "I perceive," said the King icily, "that you are no better able to control your hands than your tongue." Once at Marly, Mme. de Torcy, wife of a minister, took a seat above a duchess at supper. Louis, to her extreme discomfort, regarded her steadfastly throughout the meal, and when he reached Mme. de Maintenon's room, the storm broke; he had, he said, witnessed a piece of insolence so intolerable that the sight of it had prevented him from eating: a piece of presumption which would have been unendurable in a woman of quality. It took the combined efforts of Mme. de Maintenon and the Duchess of Burgundy the rest of the evening to pacify him. Decidedly not a king with whom to take liberties, or even make mistakes. . . .

Fables of Telrhin
Fable 25
The Eye of Set

Evil has been said to be a frame of mind. Cruelty but the turgid extension of the will. But there are others who believe it is a way of life...

The Westron stood there, moving only his one eye as he glanced around. His feet were planted in the middle of pooling blood; a body lay on the ground. The cave was silent, with dust still in the air from the recent excavation; next to the steaming corpse lay the opened entrance to a Bardorian tomb.

"Stupid henchman. Didn't last past the first stab of my blade." he motioned to the cave opening, the hot sun pouring down outside like rain; another figure entered. This second man was a Shemite, slender and quick.

"The crew is ready to sail as soon as we return to Balrahb, Captain."

"Good. Now follow silently; we don't want the Windwraiths to have time to fight us."

Just then a scream erupted from the tomb.

"Damn. One less for us to kill."

The two slinked down the steps, making their way through the ancient pharaoh's grave. They passed the wreckage of traps and other things the adventurers had overcome. Soon they caught the glimpse of torchlight ahead.

Ahead, in a large chamber with overturned pillars, the last of the Windwraiths crossed the floor. She stopped, staring about her in some awe, her torch held high overhead. She was slim, with a pretty face and piercing eyes; there was some elf in her mingled Valek blood. The brief minute she spent in this room was her last; just as the last of her comrades crossed the threshold of the far door, a dagger slid between her shoulder blades. She gasped, blood gathering in her throat; as she stared upwards, her dying eyes met those of her murderer - he smiled cruelly and kissed her as she died.

"Where's Mindy?" asked a large, brawny fighter; he was looking back down the hall from where they'd come.

"She's got vanguard, Garop - don't you see her?"

"No. I'm going to go see what's up."

"She's probably just chiselling jewels out of the walls or something, Garop. You worry too much."

"Well, you're probably right, but I'm going to go see anyway." with that he turned from them and walked back, his torch flickering off the drawn broadsword in his hand.

The invisible blade slammed into his back, but with a flash of blue light the warrior whipped around swinging wildly - his

skin wasn't even cut.

"Ambush!" he shouted, thrusting towards his opponent. The killer easily planted his invisible knife once more, this time cutting through the heart. Garop fell dead to the ground. From the hall came his companions; the killer ducked, watching as overhead a bolt of lightning felled the first two - the Shemite smiled.

There were three left, a knight and two fighters. One of them, a young adventurer, ran into a side passage - all anyone saw was a bucket of blood toss itself back towards them.

The knight bellowed a cry and thundered for the Shemite; he lost a leg as he passed the shaded killer. Screaming he fell, blood spewing wildly about as he moved his stump in agony.

The last man stopped, fear in his eyes; he tossed three egg-shaped stones down the hall; they exploded, knocking the Shemite and Westron flat as they put the knight out of his misery. Then he grabbed a rotten egg from his pocket and tossed it as well- it broke and instantly the hall filled with Green Slime. The killers writhed in the muck, cursing, as the last Windwraith muttered a prayer and vanished.

The two got clear of the hall, the Shemite badly hurt.

"Fool. You did not tell me they had protections."

They made their slow way along the black hall, coming at last to a great chamber. The Westron stopped them just outside the door, his ear pressed to the key hole.

"He's in there."

"Willinfire?"

"Whatever his name is. Either that or the Pharaoh's still alive."

They opened the door silently, watching intently as Willinfire climbed the steps to the dais. He moved very carefully, until at last his hand moved to get the little jeweled marble that was perched atop it all. He was sweating as he edged nearer. Then he touched it.

His skin poured off his bones like hot jelly. He didn't even have time to scream. The jewel clattered to the floor and rolled for a few seconds till it stilled.

"Fool."

The Westron moved delicately to the jewel, picking it quickly from the floor. He smiled, putting it into a deep pocket.

Behind him he heard a scream - the Shemite stood, blood running from his stomach and eye sockets, as a wall of spikes transfixed him.

"Help me..." he gasped. The Westron walked to him. He looked him over and then grabbed his pouch.

He made his lonely way back through the tomb, until at last he came once again to the cave. There he sat, smiling as he smoked from a small pipe, and examined his prize; it looked like an eyeball made from ruby. He lifted his eyepatch and set it into his skull - he screamed, falling back, and stopped moving. Then, slowly, he sat up. He smiled darkly, and closed his good

eye; with his new one he gazed about.

"Thanks be to Set."

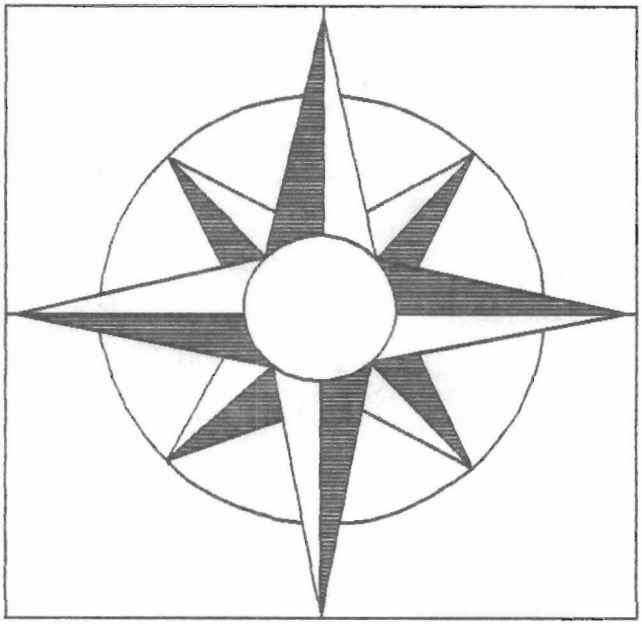
That evening, after he crossed the deserts of Bardor, the Westron climbed aboard his ship - the pirate ship Everbad.

The Story of the Magical Mountain.

Once upon a time, a long, long, time ago, there lived a little boy named Thomas, and his sister, who he loved dearly,Susan. They lived with their parents in the Swiss Alps, in a cabin high, high in the mountains, where there was snow. They lived a good life in their small cozy cabin, warmed by the wood stove that burned the firewood that Papa chopped. Every day, Papa and Thomas got up before the sun- there were many chores to be done. First, Bray, the donkey had to be tended to.Thomas would give Bray clean food and water,brush him down and clean out the stall. Meanwhile, Papa milked Bessie, the cow. Thomas wasn't allowed-he was too small. You see, Bessie was sometimes grumpy when you woke her up early in the morn with cold hands. Then, both Thomas and Papa tended the chickens. They checked for new eggs, and gave them food and water. Meanwhile, Mama and Susan tended to the housecleaning and made the menfolk a hearty breakfast. After breakfast, Thomas and Susan would put on their coats, and get ready to go out. They would round up the goats and take them to a lower, warmer altitude where they could graze. Every day, Thomas and Susan found new amusementsto occupy their time. Some days,they played hide and seek. Other days, they played hopskotch. Then as they were hiking home on day, one of the goats baa-ed, and Thomas heard the echo. 'Hellooo!' Shouted Thomas 'Hellllooooo!' Returned the echo. This amused the children to no end. Soon, Susan grew impatient, and she took her turn. 'Mama, Papa! Can you hear Me?' she called.

But the stupid bitch shouted too loud, and caused an earthquake.

Everyone died.



The RENEGADES

Well now, welcome to the new season of violence and gore. As you all know, a massive session of soloing is taking place in a vain effort to get you all out of *Beldigard's Tomb.* That is, to prepare you for certain death at the hands of some foul beast named Burt. In other news, we have some old fashioned adventuring on the horizon (for those of you who live): ***Ravenloft II: The House on Gryffon Hill.***

In other news: **The Sixth Edition Field Guide.** Don't hold your breath. It won't be out for a long, long while. However, the work I'm doing for it is helping me work out my infernal world, so it isn't all a waste of time.

Also: Adventure Log Magazine #37. Well, all I can say is that I hope that it's out for Christmas.